

Promises and Pressure: A Better Question

承诺与压力：更好的问题

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The better question came from a nurse in the maternity **house**: whose **family** is this, biologically speaking? A **baby** had two mothers on the form — one who carried him and one who would raise him — and the old system had only one line for both. A **great** part of the **control** belonged to whoever wrote the first column.

The **head** of the department, a **modern** man with a quiet voice, asked what a **fingerprint** was for. “Identification,” the **deputy** said. “No,” the nurse said. “It is a **pure** fact that has nothing to do with **kin**.” There was a **little** **contempt** in the room, and a **great** deal of **envy**.

A **priest**, a **spouse**, a parent, and a student stood around the table. “The **whole** **function** of a form is to decide what counts,” the **priest** said. “A **palm**, a **wound**, a **bite** on the arm: three ways of saying the same thing.” **Half** the **name**, a **figure**, an **active** **feature** of the **throat**: the **primitive** grammar of the form decided everything before the nurse spoke. The president of the union wrote it down.

A **sympathetic** social worker showed them a **secret** file with a **facial** photograph of a **baby**, a **blood** test, and a feeding schedule. “Is that biology or care?” she asked. “Both,” Maya said. “And the form makes you choose.” A black cat crossed the **litter** in the yard, **indifferent** to all of it.

The **envelope** on the table contained two forms: one **biological**, one social. “Which one does the **breast** belong to,” the nurse asked, “when the **baby** will not feed?” Nobody answered. The **baby** was weighed again, the figures were written down, and the second mother came back from the corridor with a bottle and a blanket, then carried the empty tray away.

The **expansive** claim — that a **commune** could replace a **family** — was met with silence. “A **relay** is not a race,” Lin wrote, “and a **harness** is not a horse.” The **oceanic** feeling of the room was mostly fatigue. “**Something** has to change in the **double** column,” the nurse said. “The **skin** of the form, not the **skin** of the child.” Of course the father of the second mother was sure that the form would lose the case; but a person who has never filled in such a form has no idea what it costs.

中文翻译

更好的问题来自产房的一位护士：从生物学上说，这是谁的家庭？表格上一个婴儿有两位母亲——一位生了他，一位要养育他——而旧系统只为两者留了一行。很大一部分控制权属于写下第一栏的人。

系主任是一位声音安静的现代人，他问指纹有什么用。“身份识别，”副主任说。“不，”护士说，“它是一个与血缘毫无关系的纯粹事实。”屋里有一点轻蔑，也有很多嫉妒。

一位神父、一位配偶、一位家长和一名学生围在桌旁。“表格的整个功能就是决定什么算数，”神父说，“一只手掌、一处创伤、手臂上的一口咬痕：三种说法，同一件事。”半个名字、一个数字、喉咙的一项活跃特征：表格那原始的语法在护士开口之前就决定了一切。工会主席把它记了下来。

一位富有同情心的社工给他们看了一份秘密档案：一张婴儿的面部照片、一次血液检验和一份喂养时间表。“那是生物学还是照料？”她问。“都是，”曼雅说，“而表格逼你二选一。”一只黑猫穿过院子里的杂物，对这一切漠不关心。

桌上的信封里装着两份表格：一份生物学的，一份社会性的。“当婴儿不肯吃奶的时候，乳房属于哪一份？”护士问。没有人回答。婴儿被重新称重，数字被记下，第二位母亲从走廊回来，手里拿着奶瓶和一条毯子，随后把空托盘端走了。

那个扩张性的主张——社区可以取代家庭——遇到了沉默。“接力不是赛跑，”林伟写道，“马具也不是马。”屋里那种海洋般的感觉多半是疲惫。“双栏里必须改点什么，”护士说，“改表格的皮，不是孩子的皮。”当然，第二位的母亲的父亲认定这场官司会输；但一个从未填过这种表格的人，根本不知道它要付出什么。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
great greɪt POS: a	a. 大的, 非常的, 主要的, 重大的, 崇高的, 伟大的; adv. 顺利地, 得意地; n. 全部, 大人物, 大师 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who has achieved distinction and honor in some field; s. relatively large in size or number or ext...
something 'sʌmθɪŋ POS: pron	pron. 某事, 某物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. Anything unknown, undetermined, or not specifically; designated; a certain indefinite thing; an indetermin...
family 'fæməli POS: n	n. 家庭, 家人, 族; a. 家庭的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a social unit living together; n. primary social group; parents and children; n. people descended from a com...
house haus POS: n	n. 房子, 住宅, 机构, 议院, 家族, 家庭; vt. 给...房子住, 收藏; vi. 住, 躲藏 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a dwelling that serves as living quarters for one or more families; n. the members of a religious community...
head hed POS: n	n. 头, 头脑, 领袖, 脑袋, 最前的部分; vt. 为首, 朝向, 前进, 用头顶; vi. 朝特定方向行进, (作物)结穗; a. 头的... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the upper part of the human body or the front part of the body in animals; contains the face and brains; n. ...
little 'lɪtl POS: n	n. 一点点, 少许, 一会儿, 短时间; a. 小的, 很少的, 幼小的, 琐碎的, 短暂的, 矮小的; adv. 很少, 稍微, 完全不 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small amount or duration; a. (quantifier used with mass nouns) small in quantity or degree; not much or a...
name neɪm POS: n	n. 名字, 名称, 姓名, 名义, 名誉, 文件名; vt. 命名, 称呼, 任命, 提名, 列举; a. 姓名的, 据以取名的; [计] 名... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a language unit by which a person or thing is known; n. a person's reputation; n. family based on male desce...
figure 'fɪɡə POS: n	n. 数字, 价格, 图形, 形状; vt. 描绘, 表示, 演算, 认为; vi. 计算, 出现, 估计 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a diagram or picture illustrating textual material; n. a model of a bodily form (especially of a person); n. ...
control kən'trəʊl POS: n	n. 控制, 管理, 克制, 控制器, 操纵装置; vt. 控制, 操纵, 抑制; [计] 控制; 控制器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. power to direct or determine; n. a relation of constraint of one entity (thing or person or group) by anoth...
whole həʊl POS: n	n. 全部, 全体, 整体, 完全之体系; a. 所有的, 完整的, 完全的, 纯粹的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. all of something including all its component elements or parts; n. an assemblage of parts that is regarded...
half hɑ:f POS: n	n. 一半, 半场, 不完全; a. 一半的, 不完全的, 部分的, 半场的; adv. 一半地, 部分地, 在某种程度上地, 几乎 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. one of two divisions into which some games or performances are divided: the two divisions are separated by...
baby 'beɪbi POS: n	n. 婴孩; [医] 婴儿 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a very young child (birth to 1 year) who has not yet begun to walk or talk; n. the youngest member of a gro...
blood blʌd POS: n	n. 血, 血统, 流血, 气质, 生命; vt. 使出血, 用血涂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the fluid (red in vertebrates) that is pumped through the body by the heart and contains plasma, blood cel...
feature 'fi:tʃə POS: n	n. 面孔的一部分(如眼、口等), 特征, 容貌, 特色, 特写; vt. 是...的特色, 特写, 放映; vi. 起重要作用; [计] 特性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a prominent attribute or aspect of something; n. the characteristic parts of a person's face: eyes and nose...
modern 'mɒdən POS: n	n. 现代人, 有思想的人; a. 现代的, 时髦的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a contemporary person; n. a typeface (based on an 18th century design by Gianbattista Bodoni) distinguished...
function 'fʌŋkʃən POS: n	n. 官能, 职务, 功能, 函数; vi. 活动, 运行, 行使职责; [计] 功能, 函数 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (mathematics) a mathematical relation such that each element of a given set (the domain of the function) i...
skin skɪn POS: n	n. 皮肤, 皮; vt. 剥皮, 在...植皮; vi. 长皮, 愈合, 蜕皮 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a natural protective body covering and site of the sense of touch; n. an outer surface (usually thin); n. a...
active 'æktɪv POS: a	a. 活跃的, 起作用的, 积极的, 有效的, 主动的, 活性的, 现行的, 现役的; n. 主动语态, 积极分子 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who is a participating member of an organization; a. tending to become more severe or wider in sco...
double 'dʌbl POS: n	n. 两倍; a. 两倍的, 双重的; vt. 使加倍; vi. 加倍, 代替, 快步走; [计] 双精度型 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a base hit on which the batter stops safely at second base; n. a stand-in for movie stars to perform danger...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
breast brest POS: n	n. 胸部, 乳房, 胸怀; vt. 以胸对着, 面对 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the front of the trunk from the neck to the abdomen; n. either of two soft fleshy milk-secreting glandular...
deputy 'depjuti POS: n	n. 副手, 代理人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone authorized to exercise the powers of sheriff in emergencies; n. an assistant with power to act when...
secret 'si:krit POS: n	n. 秘密, 机密, 秘诀, 秘方; a. 秘密的, 极机密的, 隐蔽的, 暗中的, 神秘的, 偏僻的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something that should remain hidden from others (especially information that is not to be passed on); n. in...
priest pri:st POS: n	n. 祭司, 牧师, 神父, 神质人员, 僧侣, 泰斗 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a clergyman in Christian churches who has the authority to perform or administer various religious rites;...
pure pjue POS: a	a. 纯的, 纯净的, 纯洁的, 清白的, 完美的, 无瑕的, 抽象的; [医] 的, 纯净的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. free of extraneous elements of any kind; s. free from discordant qualities; s. concerned with theory and dat...
throat θrəut POS: n	n. 咽喉, 喉咙, 嗓音; vt. 用喉音说, 开沟于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the passage to the stomach and lungs; in the front part of the neck below the chin and above the collarbon...
biological 'baɪəʊ'lɒdʒɪkəl POS: a	a. 生物学的; [医] 生物学的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. pertaining to biology or to life and living things; a. of parents and children; related by blood
palm pɑ:m POS: n	n. 手掌, 棕榈, 胜利; vt. 与...握手, 藏...于掌中 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the inner surface of the hand from the wrist to the base of the fingers; n. a linear unit based on the leng...
bite bait POS: n	n. 咬, 一口; v. 咬, 刺痛, 穿透 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a wound resulting from biting by an animal or a person; n. a light informal meal; n. (angling) an instance o...
wound wu:nd POS: n	n. 创伤, 伤口, 伤疤, 伤害, 痛苦; vt. 伤害, 损害, 使受伤; vi. 打伤, 伤害; wind的过去式和过去分词 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an injury to living tissue (especially an injury involving a cut or break in the skin); n. a casualty to mi...
envelope 'envəleʊp POS: n	n. 信封, 封套, 封袋; [医] 膜, 包装袋 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a flat (usually rectangular) container for a letter, thin package, etc.; n. any wrapper or covering; n. a cu...
spouse spauz POS: n	n. 配偶 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person's partner in marriage
primitive 'prɪmɪtɪv POS: n	n. 原始人, 早期艺术家; a. 原始的, 上古的; [计] 图元; 原语; 基元 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who belongs to an early stage of civilization; n. a mathematical expression from which another exp...
sympathetic 'sɪmpə'θetɪk POS: a	a. 有同情心的, 合意的, 赞成的; n. 交感神经, 容易感受的人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to the sympathetic nervous system; a. expressing or feeling or resulting from sympathy or co...
contempt kən'tempt POS: n	n. 轻视, 轻蔑; [法] 藐视, 侮辱, 轻视 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. lack of respect accompanied by a feeling of intense dislike; n. a manner that is generally disrespectful an...
facial 'feɪʃəl POS: n	n. 美颜, 脸部按摩; a. 脸的, 表面的, 脸部用的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. cranial nerve that supplies facial muscles; n. care for the face that usually involves cleansing and massag...
litter 'lɪtə POS: n	n. 垃圾, 杂乱, 轿, 担架; vt. 乱丢, 铺草, 弄乱; vi. 产仔, 乱丢垃圾 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the offspring at one birth of a multiparous mammal; n. rubbish carelessly dropped or left about (especially...
kin kin POS: n	n. 亲戚, 同族, 血缘关系, 家族; a. 有亲属关系的, 性质类似的, 同类的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person having kinship with another or others; n. group of people related by blood or marriage
fingerprint 'fɪŋɡəprɪnt POS: n	n. 指纹; vt. 采指纹 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a print made by an impression of the ridges in the skin of a finger; often used for biometric identificati...
indifferent ɪn'dɪfərənt POS: a	a. 漠不关心的, 无重要性的, 中立的; [医] 中性的, 无作用的, 无亲和力的, 淡漠的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. showing no care or concern in attitude or action; s. fairly poor to not very good; s. marked by no especial...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
relay 'ri:lei POS: n	n. 驿马, 替班, 中继, 接力; vt. 分程传递, 转播, 使接替; vi. 接力传送, 转播 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of passing something along from one person or group to another; n. a crew of workers who relieve an...
envy 'envi POS: n	n. 羡慕, 嫉妒; vt. 羡慕, 嫉妒 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a feeling of grudging admiration and desire to have something that is possessed by another; n. spite and re...
harness 'hɑ:nis POS: n	n. 马具, 挽具状带子, 甲冑; vt. 给...上挽具, 驾驭, 披上甲冑, 利用...以产生动力 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a support consisting of an arrangement of straps for holding something to the body (especially one support...
expansive ik'spænsiv POS: a	a. 扩张性的, 使扩大的, 广阔的; [化] 膨胀的: 可以膨胀的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. able or tending to expand or characterized by expansion; s. of behavior that is impressive and ambitious in...
commune kə'mju:n POS: n	n. 愚谈, 社区, 公社; vi. 亲密交谈, (感情上)融为一体 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the smallest administrative district of several European countries; n. a body of people or families living...
oceanic ,əuʃi'ænik POS: a	a. 海洋的, 产于海洋的, 在海洋中生活的, 广阔的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an eastern subfamily of Malayo-Polynesian languages; a. relating to or occurring or living in or frequentin...